

Sitios de Memoria: Guanajuato in the Shadow of the Bicentenario

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Introduction

• Guanajuato, Guanajuato, four hours northwest of Mexico City

• Deep intellectual and cultural roots

• Tourists from the United States, the European Union, and other cities and states within Mexico as well

• Bicentennial of Mexican Independence and the centennial of the beginning of the Mexican Revolution

• The cradle of Independence

• Analyze sites of memory for Guanajuato, Mexico, in light of the bicentennial celebrations and festivities for the centennial anniversary
  • Examine how each plays key roles in the development of Guanajuato's legitimacy within Mexico and how each also serves to instill in Mexicans a sense of identity and place

Research Questions

• How do historical sites in Guanajuato promote and instill a sense of national and local identity through the recollection of memory?

• Who has historically been in charge of highlighting the importance of these sites?

• How were the 1910 festivities for the centennial anniversary of Independence organized and what were their purpose?

Literature Review

History, sites of memory, collective memory and identity

• In *Signos de identidad: los espacios simbólicos de Dolores Hidalgo*, Vázquez Soriano found that historic sites in Dolores Hidalgo, Guanajuato, contributed to the creation of a "national identity"

• Ricardo Mejía Falcón argues in "Construcción histórico de la imagen urbana de GTO: Estudio sobre la transición de la identidad minera a la turística, 1949-1955," that, by the onset of the Revolution, interest toward 'hispanofilia' led a distinguished social group to idealize the city's colonial past

Promoters of a national identity

• According to "La historia y el rescate cultural: la memoria colectiva pictórica, oral y escrita" by Patricia Campos Rodríguez, collective memory has been created and recreated through oral communication
  • These are processes of selection and are transformed from the past
  • Processes have been initiated by the State

• History permits one to construct their identity as a sign of belonging to a particular group, community, region or nation

• Mendoza Garcia argues that all cultural history derives from something in "El transcurrir de la memoria colectiva: La identidad"
  • All cultural identities are created on the bases of experience, memory, tradition, and a variety of practices and cultural expression

• The ability to remember and re-remember something about the past is the key that sustains identity

Centennial celebrations of 1910

• In "Imagining Mexico in 1910: Visions of the *Patria*," Gonzales argues that the 1910 *Centenario* served to promote political agendas and philosophies through the construction of historical memory

• As detailed in *Los aniversarios del 16 de septiembre* by González Obregón, the most important of Mexican celebrations are those of September 16, "a day of eternal memories for every Mexican that appreciates freedom"

Discussion

• Sites intended to create a national identity among Mexican citizens, as well as maintain the sociocultural and regional identity of guanajuatenses

• Histories have become myths and the iconic heroes of the Independence and revolutionary movements have become idolized in their memories

• Nationalized in a way that encourages and promotes the development and conservation of a national identity that falsely homogenizes the Mexican population

• Historical sites have been commodified in search of popularizing *Mexicanidad* since 1910

• Guanajuato, however, may be more stable than initially considered

Further Research

• Collective memory theory

• Investigate the performativity of cultural practices and the ways in which human beings recall in the present

• Integrate my findings with the 200-year history to draw connections between the different time periods, different ruling parties, and the differing narratives of those times, and see how those have possibly impacted the practice of informing national memory

Historical Timeline

1810

1810 — On September 16, Father Miguel Hidalgo y Costilla sounds the church bell in Dolores, Guanajuato, urging the people to join the movement against the Spanish crown. In Atotonilco, Hidalgo raises the banner of the Virgen de Guadalupe as the emblem of the movement

1810 — Attack and capture of the Alhóndiga de Granaditas on September 28

1810 — After the battle in Monte de las Cruces, Hidalgo decides to retreat from Mexico City despite their victory, causing many to abandon the campaign

1811 — On July 30, Hidalgo is executed by a firing squad after being excommunicated from the Church

1821 — Agustín de Iturbide proclaims the Plan de Iguala and organizes the insurgent army, guaranteeing religion, independence and union

1906 — June: Strike in the mines of Cananea in Sonora for equal pay and treatment

1907 — Workers in textile factories of Río Blanco, Veracruz, strike against the working conditions they face, including their 12-hour work days and highly taxed salaries

1908 — U.S. journalist James Creelman interviews President Porfirio Díaz, who states that Mexico is ready for a democracy and that by 1910, he would leave the presidency

1910

1910 — Francisco I. Madero is elected as the presidential candidate for the Anti-Re-electionist Party, but is arrested. Díaz retakes the presidency on July 10

1910 — Díaz presides over the festivities for the centennial anniversary of Mexican independence on September 15-16

1910 — On November 25, Emiliano Zapata proclaims the Plan de Ayala and raises in arms against the Madero regime for not fulfilling the promises of the Plan de San Luis, meanwhile also introducing agrarian reform into the revolutionary movement

1910 — Madero proclaims the Plan de San Luis Potosí, evoking Mexicans to take arms against the Porfirian presidency beginning on November 20

1911 — The Constitution of 1917 is passed and implemented

1914 — To avoid dividing the revolutionary factions, delegates from Obregon's division and from Villa's division agree to ally themselves and convoke a Convention

1917

2010